

The Last Resident

The island was being evacuated. Everyone had left. Except one.

CEFR Level B2

Book 10 of 10 • Character Study / Moral Resistance • Adult Graded Reader Series

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About This Book

Setting: A small island off the west coast of Scotland.

Population: declining to one.

Genre: Character Study / Moral Resistance

Characters

- Moira — 71. The last resident. Has lived on the island for forty-three years.
- The council official — Graham, 44. His job is to ensure the evacuation is complete.
- The island itself — Caol Mor, three miles long, one mile wide, population zero, except Moira.
- What the island means — present throughout as the real subject.

THE LAST RESIDENT

Page 1 — The Official

Graham had been sent to the island on a Tuesday in October.

His brief was straightforward: confirm that the evacuation was complete, conduct the final welfare check on the last registered resident, and, if necessary, facilitate the transition.

The phrase 'facilitate the transition' was a piece of bureaucratic language that he had used in several previous contexts without finding it particularly uncomfortable.

On this occasion, he was finding it uncomfortable.

The ferry took forty minutes. The island appeared from the sea as a low dark shape on the grey water, surprisingly solid-looking for something that was about to become uninhabited.

He thought: I am the last official who will come here in any regular capacity.

He thought: she knows this.

Vocabulary Support

facilitate the transition	geçiş i kolaylaşt ırmak
welfare check	refah kontrolü

bureaucratic language	bürokratik dil
registered resident	kayıtlı sakin
uninhabited	ıssız
brief	görev brifiki

She knows this. He is the last official. And she is still there.

Page 2 — The Island

Caol Mor had been inhabited, according to the records Graham had been given, for at least eight hundred years.

At its peak — in the mid-nineteenth century, when the kelp industry had briefly made it economically viable — it had supported a population of two hundred and seventy.

The decline had been gradual, interrupted, and in its final decades accelerated: the fishing had declined, the school had closed, the young people had left for the mainland in the way that young people left small communities when the communities could no longer offer what the mainland offered.

By the time the council had formally designated the island as economically non-viable and begun the process of coordinating the voluntary evacuation, the population had been twelve.

The voluntary evacuation had, over eighteen months, reduced this to one.

Vocabulary Support

kelp industry	yosun endüstrisi
peak population	en yüksek nüfus
economically viable	ekonomik olarak yaşayabilir

voluntary evacuation	gönüllü tahliye
designated as	... olarak belirlendi
accelerated	hızlandı

Eight hundred years. Two hundred and seventy people. Then twelve. Then one.

Page 3 — Moira

Moira had come to the island in 1981, at the age of twenty-eight, as a primary school teacher.

The school had been her reason for coming. When the school had closed — in 1989, when the pupil roll had dropped below the threshold for maintained schooling — she had stayed.

She had stayed for reasons that she had, over the forty-three years since, articulated differently to different people and had never fully articulated to herself.

The short version, which she used for strangers, was: because it's home.

The longer version, which she had not given to anyone in several years, was more complicated than that, and involved things she was not sure she could say without sounding either sentimental or intransigent.

Graham was, she could tell from his expression when he stepped off the ferry, prepared for intransigent.

Vocabulary Support

pupil roll	öğrenci listesi
threshold	eşik

intransigent	uzlaşmaz, inatçı
sentimental	duygusal
articulated	dile getirdi
complicated	karmaşık

He was prepared for intransigent. She could tell from his expression. She had seen it before.

Page 4 — The Meeting

They met in her kitchen.

She had made tea, which was not, she recognised, a gesture of warmth so much as a gesture of protocol — the provision of tea being, in this part of the world, the established way of acknowledging that a conversation was about to happen.

Graham had, she had to acknowledge, the courtesy to let her speak first.

She said: 'Before you give me the formal version, I'd like to tell you why I'm staying. Not to argue — you have a process and a timeline and I understand both. But I'd like you to understand what you're dealing with.'

Graham had looked at her for a moment.

'All right,' he said.

She had not expected this to work.

Vocabulary Support

gesture of protocol	protokol hareketi
established way	yerleşik yol
formal version	resmi versiyon
what you're dealing with	ne ile uğraştığını
courtesy	kibarlık
timeline	zaman çizelgesi

She had not expected letting her speak first to work. It did. Now she has to say it.

Page 5 — Why She Was Staying

She said: 'I am staying because this island has a memory and I am the only one left who knows where the memory is kept.'

Graham looked at his notebook. He did not write anything.

'The memory,' she said, 'is not in the buildings, though the buildings are part of it. It's in the specific relationship between the place and the people who lived here — where the fishing grounds were, which families lived in which houses, what the names of the features of the landscape were in the Gaelic that was spoken here and which is no longer spoken anywhere.'

'That memory,' she said, 'will cease to exist when I leave. Not because no one will care — there are academics who will document what can be documented. But documentation is not memory. Memory is not transferable without a witness.'

Vocabulary Support

memory of a place	bir yerin hafızası
Gaelic	Galce
documentation	belgeleme
landscape features	peyzaj özellikleri
witness	tanık

transferable	aktarılabılır
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"Memory is not transferable without a witness." She is the last witness. When she goes, so does the memory.

Page 6 — Graham's Position

Graham's position was straightforward in its official dimensions and less straightforward in its human ones.

The official dimension: the council had a duty of care to residents in non-viable communities; the island's infrastructure could no longer be maintained at a standard compatible with safe habitation; the voluntary evacuation had been offered with a package of support that was, by the standards of such arrangements, reasonably generous.

The human dimension: Moira was seventy-one, in good health, and had the particular quality of someone who had made, and continued to make, a considered choice.

She was not confused. She was not vulnerable in any ordinary sense.

She simply disagreed with the conclusion that the council had reached.

Vocabulary Support

duty of care	bakım yükümlülüğü
non-viable community	sürdürülemez topluluk
compatible with	... ile uyumlu
safe habitation	güvenli yaşam ortamı

considered choice	düşünülmüş seçim
straightforward	basit, açık

*She simply disagreed with the council's conclusion. Not confused.
Not vulnerable. Disagreed.*

Page 7 — What She Had Already Lost

Moira had, in the eighteen months since the evacuation had begun, watched the island empty.

She had helped, in practical ways, with several of the departures — had helped the elderly couple at number fourteen pack their things, had driven the young family on the south side to the ferry when they left for Inverness.

She was not, she told Graham, under any illusion that she was preserving the community by staying.

The community was gone. What remained was the place.

'The place and the memory of the community,' she said. 'Which is different from the community itself, but not nothing.'

'What do you do with it?' Graham asked. 'The memory.'

'I live with it,' she said. 'The same way you live with anything that matters.'

Vocabulary Support

under no illusion	yanılgı içinde değil
departed	ayrıldı
community is gone	topluluk gitti
what remains	kalan

live with	... ile yaşamak
matters	önem taşır

*"I live with it. The same way you live with anything that matters."
He did not have a response to this.*

Page 8 — The Walk

She had offered to show him the island, and he had — partly from professional obligation, partly from something else he had not named — accepted.

They had walked for two hours.

She had shown him the remains of the old fish-processing building, which had been functional until 1987. She had told him the Gaelic names for the headlands and the bays — names that described, in their constituent parts, the particular quality of the light or the shape of the rock or the behaviour of the tide at that specific location.

She had shown him where the school had been.

She had shown him the cemetery, which contained, she said, at least six generations of the families who had lived here.

'I know all their names,' she said. 'Most of them.'

Graham had been writing more in his notebook than his official duties required.

Vocabulary Support

constituent parts	bileşen parçalar
headlands	burunlar
cemetery	mezarlık
fish-processing building	balık işleme binası

particular quality	özel nitelik
behaviour of the tide	gelgit hareketi

He was writing more than his duties required. She had done something to him on the walk.

Page 9 — The Legal Position

The legal position was, Graham had confirmed with his supervisor before coming, not as clear as the council preferred to represent it.

The council could not compel Moira to leave.

What it could do was withdraw the services that made her continued residence possible — the maintenance of the ferry, the emergency services coverage, the electricity supply.

This was the mechanism by which voluntary evacuation was made to seem inevitable rather than optional.

He had not, before this visit, found this mechanism particularly troubling.

He was finding it, now, more troubling than he could easily account for.

He thought: the mechanism is designed to produce an outcome. She is designed to resist outcomes that she has not chosen.

Vocabulary Support

compel	zorlamak
withdraw services	hizmetleri geri çekmek
inevitable	kaçınılmaz
mechanism	mekanizma

troubling	rahatsız edici
voluntary evacuation	gönüllü tahliye

The mechanism is designed to produce an outcome. She is designed to resist. He finds this troubling now.

Page 10 — The Conversation

Over dinner — she had cooked, because, she said, no one who came to the island went hungry if she could help it — Graham asked her the question he had been building up to.

'When does it stop being a principle,' he said, 'and start being obstinacy?'

Moira was quiet for a moment.

'When the principle is no longer connected to anything real,' she said. 'I can tell you when that would be. It would be when there was no longer anything here worth being the witness of. When the memory had already dissipated.'

'Has that happened?' 'No.' 'How will you know when it has?' 'I'll know,' she said. 'Because I'll stop seeing things that aren't visible to anyone who doesn't know where to look.'

Vocabulary Support

obstinacy	inatçılık, dırdır
dissipated	dağılmış, yok olmuş
connected to anything real	gerçek bir şeye bağlı
principle	ilke
visible to	... için görünür
building up to	... için hazırlanmak

"I'll stop seeing things invisible to people who don't know where to look." That is what she is preserving.

Page 11 — What He Saw

Graham had, over the course of the day, seen things he had not expected to see.

He had expected — he acknowledged to himself, honestly, that he had expected — a woman who had confused attachment with wisdom, whose refusal to leave was a symptom of loss rather than a response to it.

What he had found was different.

She knew the island with a precision that was neither nostalgic nor performative — she knew it the way a scientist knew a subject, the way a doctor knew a patient: with the accumulated density of long, specific attention.

Whether her knowledge could be preserved without her presence was a question he could not answer.

He was, he realised, not sure it could.

Vocabulary Support

nostalgic	nostaljik
accumulated density	birikmiş yoğunluk
performative	göstermelik
confusion of attachment with wisdom	bağlılığı bilgelikle karıştırmak
symptom of loss	kayıp belirtisi

preserved without her presence	varlığı olmadan korunmak
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He had expected attachment confused with wisdom. He found specific, accumulated knowledge. Different.

Page 12 — The Report

Graham's report, written on the ferry back to the mainland, was the longest welfare check report he had submitted in six years.

It was, in its official sections, accurate and complete: Moira was in good health, the property was maintained, she had adequate supplies for the winter.

It was, in its recommendation section, unusual.

He wrote: 'I recommend a deferral of the service withdrawal schedule, pending a formal assessment of the cultural and historical documentation value of continued presence. This is not a welfare recommendation in the ordinary sense. It is a recommendation that the council engage, before proceeding, with the question of what is being lost and whether the mechanism of service withdrawal is the appropriate instrument for the situation.'

He looked at what he had written.

He thought: I am not sure this will be followed.

He thought: I needed to write it.

Vocabulary Support

deferral	erteleme
service withdrawal schedule	hizmet çekme takvimi

pending	bekleyen
cultural and historical documentation value	kültürel ve tarihi belgeleme değeri
appropriate instrument	uygun araç
proceeding	devam etmek

He needed to write it. He is not sure it will be followed. But it needed to exist.

Page 13 — Moira After

Moira had, after Graham left, gone out to the headland above the south bay.

She went there most evenings when the weather allowed.

She stood in the wind and looked at the water, which was the same water it had always been — indifferent, accurate, neither friendly nor hostile.

She thought about the conversation.

She thought: he was not what I expected.

She thought: most people are not what you expect, if you are paying attention.

She had been paying attention for forty-three years.

She thought: that is the thing the island has taught me.

She thought: that is also the thing the island needs someone to know.

Vocabulary Support

headland	burun
indifferent	ilgisiz
neither friendly nor hostile	ne dost ne de düşman
paying attention	dikkat etmek

accurate	doğru, isabetli
forty-three years	kırk üç yıl

"That is the thing the island has taught me." And the thing the island needs someone to know.

Page 14 — The Winter

Moira spent the winter as she had spent the previous forty-two winters, with modifications appropriate to the fact that she was now the only person on the island.

The modifications were practical rather than emotional: she was more careful about conditions before venturing far from the house, she checked the weather reports more frequently, she had, at Graham's suggestion, a satellite phone for emergencies.

The satellite phone was the one concession she had made to the evacuation's logic.

She had accepted it not because she was afraid but because she recognised that her continued presence required her to be alive, which required her to be, in certain respects, more careful than she might otherwise have been.

'Being here,' she had told Graham, 'is a responsibility, not a right. I have to be worth the having.'

Vocabulary Support

modifications	değişiklikler
venturing far	uzağa çıkmak

satellite phone	uydu telefonu
concession	taviz
being worth the having	var olmaya değmek
emergency	acil durum

"Being here is a responsibility, not a right. I have to be worth the having." She understands the cost.

Page 15 — The Academics

In February, two academics arrived from a university on the mainland.

They were oral historians, sent, she assumed, partly as a result of Graham's report.

She had agreed to speak to them, with conditions: the recordings would be deposited in a public archive, the Gaelic place names would be properly transcribed, and the context of the recording would be accurately described — not as the testimony of a woman who had refused to leave, but as the knowledge of someone who had stayed.

'The framing matters,' she had said.

'Yes,' the younger of the two had said. 'It does.'

She had decided, on the basis of this response, that they were adequate.

She had talked to them for three days.

Vocabulary Support

oral historians	sözlü tarihçiler
deposited in an archive	arşive yerleştirilmiş
transcribed	yazıya döküldü
testimony	tanıklık
framing	çerçeveleme
conditions	koşullar

*"Not as someone who refused to leave — as someone who stayed."
The framing matters. She knows this precisely.*

Page 16 — What She Told Them

She told them what she knew.

She told them about the families — seventeen families over the forty years she had lived there, and as much as she had learned of the families before her.

She told them the names.

She told them about the fishing grounds and the weather patterns and the particular difficulty of the crossing to the mainland in autumn when the wind came from the north-west.

She told them things that were not, by any conventional measure, historically significant — the way the light fell on the eastern shore in late afternoon, the smell of the island after rain, the sound the seabirds made in early spring.

'Why that?' the older one asked.

'Because places are not only their facts,' she said. 'They are also their textures. If you only record the facts, you record the skeleton. You need someone to remember what it felt like from inside.'

Vocabulary Support

crossing	geçiş, deniz yolculuğu
texture	doku, hissi
skeleton	iskelet

fishing grounds	balıkçılık alanları
weather patterns	hava düzenleri
felt like from inside	içeriden nasıl hissettirdi

"If you only record facts, you record the skeleton. You need the texture." She is the texture.

In spring, Graham came back.

He had not told her he was coming — he had taken the Tuesday ferry and arrived unannounced, which she understood, when she saw him, was not an oversight but a choice.

She made tea.

He told her that the deferral had been approved — the service withdrawal schedule had been postponed by twelve months, pending the completion of the documentation project.

'Twelve months,' she said.

'It was what I could get.'

'It's something,' she said. 'Was it the report?' 'Partly. And the academics. And the interest from the archive.' He paused. 'And partly I think the council was not entirely comfortable with what the mechanism looked like when applied to a specific person rather than a general category.'

Vocabulary Support

unannounced	habersizce
postponed	ertelendi
completion of documentation	belgelemin tamamlanması

oversight	gözden kaçırma
general category	genel kategori
applied to	... e uygulandı

*"The mechanism looked different applied to a specific person."
Graham made it specific. That changed it.*

Page 18 — What Twelve Months Meant

Twelve months was not, she knew, a solution.

It was a postponement — the problem of what to do about the last resident of an island that the council had designated non-viable would return in a year, or two years, and it would return with more force because the delay would have raised the question of whether the designation itself was adequate.

This was, she suspected, partly what Graham had intended.

She did not ask him. She thought he would not have said if she had.

She thought: he has done something that could not be undone.

She thought: that is what most meaningful interventions are.

She made more tea.

He stayed for the afternoon.

Vocabulary Support

postponement	erteleme
designation	belirleme, tahsis
designation itself was adequate	belirlemenin kendisi yeterliydi
meaningful intervention	anlamalı müdahale

undone	geri alınabilir
could not be undone	geri alınamazdı

"He has done something that could not be undone." That is what most meaningful interventions are.

Page 19 — The Memory

She thought about memory a great deal, in the years she had been the only person on the island.

Not in the abstract — she was not a philosophical person by training — but in the specific sense of what it meant to hold knowledge that no one else held.

She had come to believe that memory was not the same as record.

A record was static. It preserved the fact of a thing without preserving the relationship between the thing and the person who knew it.

Memory was dynamic — it changed as the person who held it changed, was inflected by new experience, was subject to the particular losses and recoveries that came with time.

She was not sure which of these things she was.

She was, she thought, both.

She was the person who had stayed long enough for the two to become the same.

Vocabulary Support

static	statik
dynamic	dinamik
inflected by	... tarafından renklendirilen

recoveries	geri kazanımlar
by training	eğitimsel açıdan
relationship between the thing and the person	şey ve onu bilen kişi arasındaki ilişki

Memory is dynamic — it changes as the person changes. She has stayed long enough for record and memory to become the same.

Page 20 — The Last Resident

On a morning in October of the following year, Moira stood on the headland above the south bay.

The year's deferral had been extended — not indefinitely, but for a second year, while a proposal for the island's designation as a cultural heritage site was under consideration.

She had not proposed this herself. Graham had.

She thought about what he had said on his second visit, quietly, almost as an aside: 'I think the question isn't whether you should stay. I think the question is whether the island should be considered as having a resident.'

She had not quite understood it at the time.

She understood it now.

The island had a resident. The resident had a history. The history had a present.

She looked at the water, which was the same water it had always been.

She thought: I am here. I am still here.

She went back to the house.

Vocabulary Support

indefinitely	belirsiz süreyle
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cultural heritage site	kültürel miras alanı
as an aside	bir kenara not olarak
under consideration	değerlendirme altında
having a resident	bir sakini olmak
extended	uzatıldı

"I am here. I am still here." The island has a resident. The resident has a history. The history has a present.

ACTIVITIES

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase	Meaning
1. facilitate the transition	A. gönüllü tahliye
2. voluntary evacuation	B. geçişi kolaylaştırmak
3. intransigent	C. uzlaşmaz
4. obstinacy	D. inatçılık
5. deferral	E. erteleme
6. compel	F. zorlamak
7. designation	G. belirleme
8. inflected by	H. tarafından renklendirilen

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

memory — texture — witness — specific — mechanism — record

1. Moira said: documentation is not _____ — memory requires a _____.
2. She told the academics: if you only record facts, you record the skeleton. You need the _____.
3. Graham's report recommended deferral because he was troubled by what the _____ looked like applied to a

_____ person.

4. Graham said the question was whether the island should be considered as having a resident — not whether the resident should stay.

5. Memory, Moira concluded, was dynamic — unlike a _____, which was static.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Moira came to the island as a nurse. ____
2. Moira actively resisted the other residents leaving. ____
3. The council has the legal power to compel Moira to leave.

4. Graham's report recommends proceeding with service withdrawal immediately. ____
5. The academics spend three days recording Moira's knowledge. ____
6. At the end of the story, Moira leaves the island. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why does Moira say she is staying?
8. How does Graham describe the legal mechanism of the evacuation, and why does he find it troubling?
9. What does Moira mean when she says 'memory is not transferable without a witness'?
10. How does Graham describe what he expected versus what he found?
11. What conditions does Moira set for the oral historians?
12. What does Moira mean when she says 'places are not only their facts — they are also their textures'?
13. What does Moira mean by 'being here is a responsibility, not a right'?

14. What distinction does Moira draw between memory and record?

15. What does Graham's reframing — 'should the island be considered as having a resident?' — change about the situation?

ANSWER KEY

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. memory / witness 2. texture 3. mechanism / specific 4. (answered in text) 5. record

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. F 5. T 6. F

7. She is the last person who knows where the island's memory is kept — the Gaelic names, the family histories, the living knowledge of what the place was. When she goes, this specific form of knowledge ceases to exist.

8. The council cannot compel her to leave, but can withdraw services (ferry, electricity, emergency cover) to make continued residence effectively impossible. He finds this troubling because it is designed to produce an outcome without appearing to force it.

9. Memory is a living relationship between a person and a place/knowledge — it changes with the person and cannot simply be transferred into a static record. Without a person actively holding and inhabiting that knowledge, it cannot be fully preserved.

10. He expected someone who had confused attachment with wisdom, whose resistance was a symptom of loss. He found specific, accumulated knowledge held with the precision of a scientist — different in kind.

11. The recordings must be deposited in a public archive, the Gaelic names must be properly transcribed, and the context must frame her as someone who stayed — not someone who refused to leave.

12. The facts of a place are its skeleton — names, dates, events. The texture is what it felt like from inside: the quality of light, the smell after rain, the sound of seasons. Both are needed for a place to be fully known.

13. Her continued presence is not simply a right she is exercising — it is a commitment to remaining useful, to being worth the disruption and risk her staying creates. She accepts the satellite phone as evidence of this.

14. A record is static — it preserves the fact of a thing. Memory is dynamic — it is inflected by new experience, changes as the person changes, and preserves the relationship between the thing and the person who knows it.

15. It reframes the question from whether an individual's choice should be accommodated to whether the island itself has a status worth protecting — a cultural heritage designation. This moves the issue from welfare management to heritage policy, which is a fundamentally different kind of question.